



Coffee 'cherries' being picked in the higher reaches of a plantation in Araku Valley

ABOUT 120 KM north of Vizag in Andhra Pradesh, along the rolling hill slopes of Araku Valley in the Eastern Ghat are plantations of coffee that occupy the same space in the minds of coffee drinkers as what Darjeeling does in the minds of tea aficionados. The coffee grown in the region by the indigenous farmers of the valley under the aegis of Hyderabad-based Naandi Foundation is being acknowledged as among the finest in the world. Its primary taste is that of a revolution. For the past 15 years, a silent ecological upheaval is underway in the region in which the coffee bean is the spearhead of a transformational model of growth developed by Naandi, termed Arakunomics by The Rockefeller Foundation. This is centred on the deliberate development of native forest biodiversity, and the practice of organic, biodynamic, and regenerative agricultural techniques that is encouraged in the area by making the farmers stakehold-

ers in open and fair profit sharing of lucrative economic models, guided by very efficient marketing and high value addition of products created with global standards. What these grand words translate into on the ground is coffee that is grown as per specially earmarked 'terroirs', special pockets of biodiversity plantations with nutrient and microbe-charged soil and climate combinations that pack the 'cherries', coffee beans with dense natural sugars that yield batches with distinct clarity, natural fruity sweetness and rich complexity. Only the brightest red coffee 'cherries' are chosen for processing. The graded beans are dried in moisture-controlled units with distinct techniques of creating **specialty coffees** without the use of any chemicals or single-use plastics. These coffees range very high on global tasting parameters, and are auctioned to select buyers in micro lots that can range from ₹12,000 to ₹20,000 per kg and go up to ₹2 lakh per kg in international resale. The world is waking up to the smell of coffee from the Araku Valley.